

Tasin Academy

Opposite Of Alekanda Govt College, Barishal

Phone: 01722335722

Syed Mujtaba Ali, was an acclaimed Bengali author, academic and linguist. He was a travel enthusiast and his travelogues are regarded as precious gems in our Bangla literature. At some point of time between the two World Wars, Syed Mujtaba Ali set out on a ship from India on a journey to Europe. Leaving Sri Lanka behind, he sailed across the Arabian Sea, then along the coast of Africa, before crossing the Suez Port. Syed Mujtaba Ali's time in Egypt was punctuated by a number of funny anecdotes, both about the people and the pyramids. The following excerpt is from Syed Mujtaba Ali's travelogue, *Tales of a Voyager (Jolay Dangay)* where he gives a charming and insightful description of Egyptian food and language. Nazes Afroz translates the following excerpt.

Most Bengali meals consist of five flavours of food—bitter, savoury, hot, sour sides and desserts. The English eat only sweet and savoury preparations. They cannot stomach the hot stuff, and even less the bitter. And possibly never even know that bitters could be consumed. Hence English cuisine seems bland and tasteless to us. But the English can bake good cake-pastry-pudding, something they learned from the Italians. In my opinion, our sandesh and rasogolla are such delicacies that there is no reason to go bananas over those desserts.

Egyptian cuisine is a close cousin of Indian food of the Mughlai variety. I might not be able to prove the theory but after tasting food in many countries, it is my firm belief that imitating the Taj Mahal of cooking, the Mughals perfected after coming to India (one should not forget that they could not discover it in their own land as the Indian spices were unavailable in their motherland of Turkestan), the people in Afghanistan, Iran, the Arab land, Egypt, even Spain, have been trying to build their own little Taj of cuisine. The reach of this gastronomy has spread to East Europe's Greece, Hungary, Rumania, Yugoslavia, Albania and even Italy.

1A. Multiple Choice Questions

1. **Syed Mujtaba Ali was a/an —**
i) musician ii) scientist iii) author and linguist iv) politician
 2. **What did he do during the two World Wars?**
i) He stayed in India ii) He traveled to Europe
iii) He went to America iv) He wrote novels
 3. **English cuisine appears bland because —**
i) it uses too much spice ii) it is based on Mughal cooking
iii) it lacks hot and bitter flavors iv) it is always served cold
 4. **The book "Tales of a Voyager" was —**
i) translated by Syed Mujtaba Ali ii) written in Italian
iii) about Bengali food iv) translated by Nazes Afroz
 5. **Bengali meals typically consist of how many types of flavors?**
i) Three ii) Four iii) Five iv) Six
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1B. Short Questions

- a) Who was Syed Mujtaba Ali?
 - b) What route did he follow to reach Europe?
 - c) Why do the English find Bengali food hard to digest?
 - d) What is mentioned as a borrowed tradition in English desserts?
 - e) How does the writer describe the popularity of Indian cuisine?
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2. Table Completion

What/Who	Events/Occurrences	What/Where	When/How
Syed Mujtaba Ali	Set out on a journey	From India to (i) —	During the time of World Wars
His time in Egypt	Punctuated by funny anecdotes	About people and (ii) —	While traveling
English cuisine	Learned to bake (iii) — and puddings	From Italians	Cultural influence
Bengali meals	Include (iv) — flavors	Bitter, savoury, hot, etc.	Traditional diet
English people	Cannot digest hot and (v) — food	In their meals	Compared to Bengali food
Indian spices	Were unavailable	In Turkestan	Before Mughals came to (vi) —
Mughal Emperors	Perfected their cuisine	After arriving in India	(vii) —
Bengali sweets	Praised by author	(viii) — and rasogolla	Over English desserts
Culinary influence	Spread across (ix) —	Greece, Hungary, etc.	Gradually
English cuisine	Seems (x) — to Bengalis	Due to fewer flavors	Compared to local meals

3. Summary Writing

Write a summary of the passage in your own words, focusing on Syed Mujtaba Ali's travel experiences and his insights about global and Bengali cuisines.

_____ **Best Of Luck** _____